

The birthday party

Manju lay on her bed looking at the ceiling. She was sick. This was the third day of her fever. She felt hot and weak.

"Pst..."

What was that?

"Pst..."

Again she heard the whisper. It seemed to come from the **ceiling**. She thought she saw some movement in a corner of the ceiling. She **squinted** and looked hard. She saw a spider. The spider smiled at her. Do spiders smile?



Manju rubbed her eyes and looked again. Now the spider lifted one of its legs and waved. Manju waved back. The spider smiled broadly and waved four of her legs. Suddenly, she **swung** on a **strand** of web like a circus performer on the **trapeze**, and came sliding down to Manju.

Manju was **frightened** of spiders. But surprisingly, she was not afraid of this one.

"Hello! I'm Makhdi. What's your name?" asked the spider, swinging just over her nose.

Makhdi had golden shoes and red socks on her feet. She **wore** a lovely golden dress made of **delicate**, silky spider's web. On her head was a red **pointed** hat that **bobbed** when she spoke.

"Manju," replied the five-year-old girl and **exclaimed**, "How beautiful you look!"

"Thank you," said Makhdi, looking very **pleased**. "It's my birthday today. Come for my party!"

"How can I climb to your house?" said Manju. "And I'm sick..."

"I'll tell my father to carry you up. And my grandmother will make you well."

Makhdi came back with a huge spider who gathered her up in his many arms and carried her through a hole into the **attic**.

There Manju saw a wonderful **sight**. The attic was decorated with coloured **cobwebs**. Blue, green and yellow lights **twinkled** at the centres of the cobwebs. A lovely cake with a red candle stood on a table. There were laddoos, halwa, sandwiches, puris and sweets on tiny plates.

Makhdi took Manju to a cardboard box in a corner. She opened a tiny door and the two **went in**. It was a hospital. It had four beds. On them lay a cockroach, a lizard, a spider and a rat.



"What's happened to you?" she asked the cockroach who had a bandage around his body. "My father says you can escape a bomb attack."

"Yes," said the cockroach, "but not your mother's chappals."

"Or her broom," added the spider who had five broken legs.

"Or her dustpan," said the lizard with a broken tail.

"Or her poisoned bread," **whispered** the rat feebly.

"Grandma, this is my friend," said Makhdi. "She has fever."

Grandma **peered** over her huge glasses at Manju. She touched her forehead. She made some mixture and poured it into two tiny bottles.

"Drink one now."

Manju drank and immediately felt better.

"Drink the other tomorrow."

"Thank you, Grandma," said Manju.

Except the rat, all the others came for the birthday party. When Makhdi cut the cake, they sang "HAPPY BIRTHDAY, DEAR MAKHDI..." and gave her **presents**. Manju found a thin gold thread in her pocket and tied it round Makhdi's neck. They ate and played games.

Manju said goodbye to everyone and Makhdi's father took her back to her bed.



Her mother who was asleep, woke up, and stretching herself, saw the spider's web in the corner of the ceiling.

"Let me get my broom," she said.

Manju stopped her, "No, Ma, please don't. All creatures are our friends. Don't hurt them."

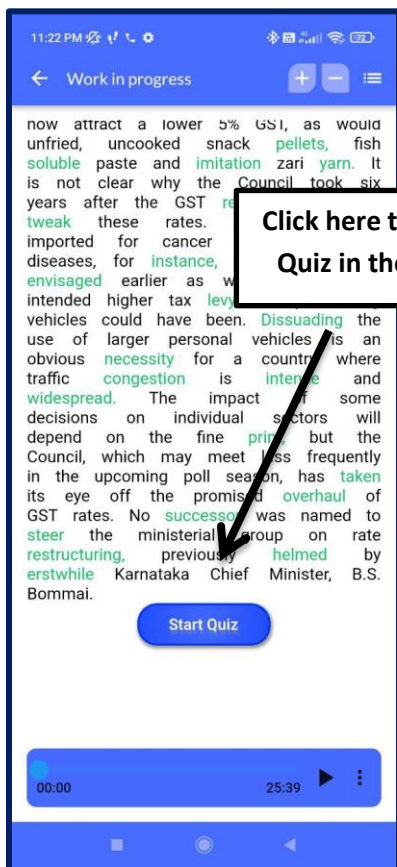
"All right, all right," said Manju's mother. She felt Manju's forehead. "Why, your fever's gone," she cried, relieved.

Manju touched the tiny bottle in her pocket, looked up and **winked** at Makhdi.

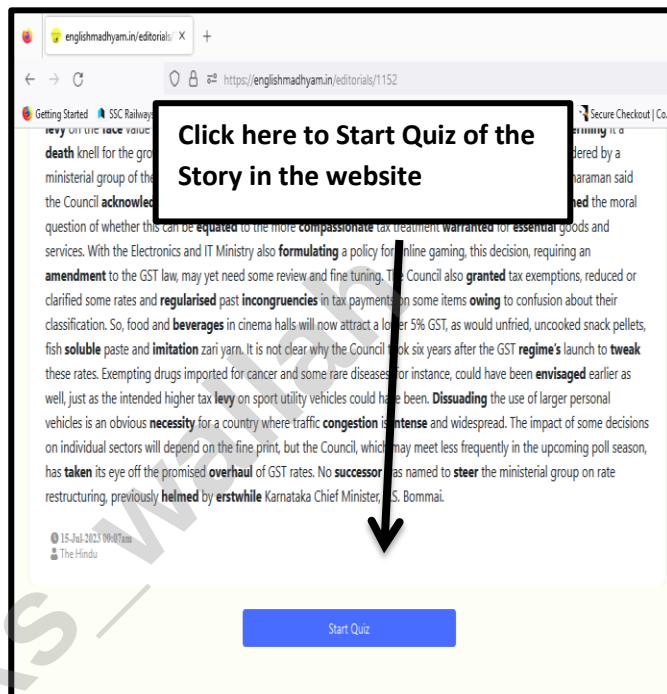
Vocabulary

1. **Ceiling** (noun) – roof, upper wall, overhead surface, top covering, canopy छत
2. **Squint** (verb) – peer, glance, peek, look narrowly, gaze झपकते हुए देखना / आँखें मिचमिचाना
3. **Swing** (verb) – sway, move back and forth, dangle, oscillate, hang झूलना
4. **Strand** (noun) – thread, string, fiber, filament, line धागा / रेशा
5. **Trapeze** (noun) – swing, aerial bar, circus apparatus, acrobatic bar, flying bar झूला (सर्कस का)
6. **Frighten** (verb) – scare, startle, terrify, intimidate, unnerve डराना
7. **Wear** (verb) – put on, dress in, be clothed in, carry, adorn पहनना
8. **Delicate** (adjective) – fragile, fine, soft, dainty, tender नाज़ुक
9. **Pointed** (adjective) – sharp, tapering, spiky, narrow-tipped, jagged नुकीला
10. **Bob** (verb) – bounce, move up and down, nod, jiggle, dip ऊपर-नीचे हिलना
11. **Exclaim** (verb) – shout, cry out, call out, utter, declare जोर से कहना / चिल्लाना
12. **Please** (verb) – delight, satisfy, gratify, charm, amuse प्रसन्न करना
13. **Attic** (noun) – loft, upper room, garret, top floor, storage space अटारी
14. **Sight** (noun) – view, scene, spectacle, vision, display दृश्य
15. **Cobweb** (noun) – spider web, webbing, mesh, gossamer, filament मकड़ी का जाला
16. **Twinkle** (verb) – sparkle, shine, shimmer, glitter, gleam चमकना
17. **Go in** (phrasal verb) – enter, step in, walk in, access, move inside अंदर जाना
18. **Whisper** (verb) – murmur, hiss, speak softly, mutter, breathe फुसफुसाना
19. **Peer** (verb) – look closely, squint, gaze, inspect, examine ध्यान से देखना
20. **Present** (noun) – gift, offering, donation, surprise, reward उपहार
21. **Wink** (verb) – blink one eye, signal, gesture, flicker, twinkle आंख मारना

Practice Exercise



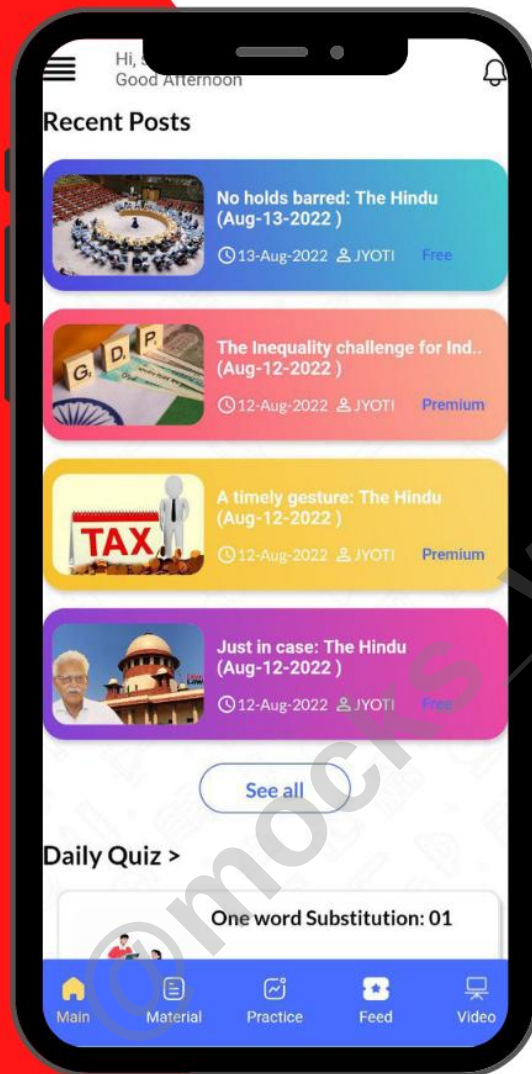
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